



MCY 121-T Hip-Hop History, Culture, and Globalization

Fall 2026

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Class Time: 5:05-6:20pm

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COURSE DESCRIPTION

A critical history and analysis of hip-hop culture in the U.S. and beyond. The course will cover major historical periods hip-hop in the U.S. beginning in the 1970s through its global impact in the 21st century. The course will also include analysis of technology, gender, race, sexuality, religion, and politics related to hip-hop culture.

*** This course is not for music majors.

PREREQUISITES

There are no prerequisites for this course and may be taken without any prior experience performing or studying music. However, you must not be enrolled in the School of Music.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

This course will explore the development of hip-hop culture and its relation to the other arts, the historical events of the times, and context in which it was created. This course is designed:

- to expand your knowledge of hip-hop musical genres, repertoire, and historical figures
- to broaden your understanding of the relationship of music with culture.
- to develop your active and critical listening skills
- to develop critical thinking skills relating to identity politics in hip-hop music cultures.
- to acquire an awareness of how hip-hop has been incorporated to non-U.S. music-cultures.

INSTRUCTIONAL METHODOLOGY

- Lectures
- Readings
- Listening exercises
- Attendance of live performances

REQUIRED MATERIALS

Orejuela, Fernando. *Rap and Hip-Hop Culture*. Oxford University Press, 2015. ***Other readings will be posted to the Canvas site.

COURSE WEB SITE

The Canvas web site for this course is available through your www.courses.miami.edu webpage. Access to the site requires use of the username and password for a regular student campus e-mail account. Students should regularly check the course site for announcements, assignment guidelines, grades, and other important and/or necessary materials. If you are unfamiliar with the Canvas system, please visit <http://www.miami.edu/it/index.php/services/Canvas/> for tutorials and further questions.

EXAMINATIONS (50%)

Three (mostly) Listening Exams (30%)

These exams comprise various topics covered in the course and are all multiple choice. All exams will be given virtually through Zoom **and** Canvas and comprise listening to songs and answering questions about those songs. Students will need to recognize genres/styles, performer, basic musical and lyrical aesthetics, and context of material found in the listening guides of the text or from lectures. Further, there will be questions similar to those on the Canvas quizzes. ***Makeup exams will only be considered with the following documentation:*** a travel letter for a UM sports team, a doctor's note of treatment for illness, or a note from a UM advisor or family member about a loss in the family. To get an absence excused for an exam, you must present documentation (i.e., doctor's note, funeral program, etc.) within **two weeks** of the administration of the exam. For example, if you miss an exam on 10/1, you have until 10/14 to bring the TA or the professor this documentation. Documentation sent after this timeframe will not be considered and the absence will not be excused. You will not be given a make-up exam. **Exams will not be made up to accommodate student travel for vacations, weddings, birthdays, anniversaries, or any other leisure time family event, so please plan accordingly.**

Final Exam (20%)

The final exam will cover the final two course topics as well as some general cumulative questions, giving you a chance to demonstrate your familiarity with the course repertoire, understanding of style and style periods, and engagement with historical and cultural context. *You must attend the final exam at the specified date on the syllabus - there will be no makeup for this test.* Please review the policies for taking final exams at http://www.miami.edu/index.php/registrar/calendar/final_exam_policy/. Due to the high level of enrollment, I will also not be making any accommodations for any student who has three finals on one day. Please see your other professors about making accommodations.

Attendance/Participation Quizzes (15%)

Class attendance is required. There will be several short online quizzes that will be posted at the end of each class. Each quiz will be available on Canvas, and I will give you the answer in class. Thus, you will know the correct answer by simply participating in the class. The quizzes are due by the end of class. You will have an ample amount of time to answer these questions **in class**. In other words, don't leave early! **If you have a technical issue with Canvas regarding quizzes, you must tell me immediately after class finishes.** I will **NOT** answer any email about technical issues related to quizzes on Canvas after class.

All questions pertaining to Canvas and regarding computer-related issues should be directed to the Canvas Helpdesk.

You are expected to attend and participate in each class. You are required to attend 80% of the classes to receive a passing grade. The ONLY way I take attendance is through participation quizzes. If you fail or fail to complete more than 6 of these, you will fail the course!

Short Video Reflections (10%)

You will be responsible for two 1-minute (1.5 min max) Short Video reflections throughout the semester (due dates on Canvas and syllabus below). Pick 1-2 hip-hop/rap songs similar to the material we've covered in class (before the 1990s for the first assignment—after the 1990s for the second assignment) and listen to it objectively. Pick 1-2 hip-hop/rap songs similar to the material we've covered in class (before the 1990s and make sure it is a hip-hop/rap song) and listen to it objectively. Then record a 1 minute response on a streaming platform or on Canvas by answering some of the following questions:

- Why do I like this song?
- What is it about the rhythm, melody, harmony, instrumentation, and timbres that make the song work for me?
- How does it make me feel?
- In which context do I like to listen to this song (i.e., at the gym, in the car, using headphones, computer, and/or home sound system)?

Your reflection will be graded on your content as well as your ability to clearly articulate why you objectively are drawn to the song(s). You should play a short part of the song in your submission to

demonstrate what elements of the music on which you choose to focus.
Either copy and paste the URL into the text box, record it on Canvas, or directly upload it to Canvas.

Album Review (10%):

Research several **hip-hop/rap** album reviews from Pitchfork (<https://pitchfork.com/reviews/albums/>), Rolling Stone (<https://www.rollingstone.com/music/music-album-reviews>), or other well-renowned journalistic publication of choice and, using those reviews as archetypes, write a 400-600 word review of a **hip-hop/rap** album of your choice.

If you choose to quote anything, you must provide your source in a works cited page or it is plagiarism! Use of AI is not permitted in writing papers. You must use traditional methods to help with grammar and spelling issues. If we suspect you are using AI, we will note that and confront you about the issue.

Concert Review (15%)

All students are required to attend a virtual *or* in-person **hip-hop** concert (minimum of **one hour**) during **THIS SEMESTER**. This means you need to watch and analyze a concert (even if you've seen it before) this semester rather than relying on your memory of a previous concert. After attending the concert, the student will complete a 1000-word (minimum) reflection paper on their musical experience, utilizing appropriate vocabulary learned in class and analytical and critical thinking strategies to assess the performance. *Performances may be pre-recorded*, but you must view them **THIS SEMESTER**. In other words, if you have previously watched a concert, you need to watch it again.

The concert review provides an opportunity for you to creatively engage with music and ideas that are of particular interest to you and are designed to develop your active listening, analytical, and critical thinking skills when applied to music. This is not a research paper – your writing should be based mostly on information from your own experience in the course. However, you are encouraged to do some background research as needed. **If you choose to quote anything, you must provide your source in a works cited page or it is plagiarism!**

If you do not write about a hip-hop concert, you will receive a 0. If you do not meet the minimum word count requirement, you will be given a 50.

You are expected to be able to express your observations in clear, accurate, and polished prose, and construct a well-organized and convincing critical synthesis of your ideas. Written assignments are graded on writing mechanics as well as content. *Specific guidelines for the concert review will be posted separately on the course Canvas site.*

Papers are to be turned in electronically on the Canvas site by the end of the day that they are due (no later than 11:59pm).

Use of AI is not permitted in writing papers. You must use traditional methods to help with grammar and spelling issues. If we suspect you are using AI, we will note that and confront you about the issue.

LATE WORK POLICY

If an assignment is not turned in via Canvas on the day it is due, it is considered late. *Each day (24hrs) an assignment is late it will be penalized 10 points (a single letter grade).* For example, a paper due on a Friday but turned in to Canvas that Sunday will automatically have 20 points deducted. Papers turned in more than two days after the due date will receive a 50% reduction. **I do not accept any late work more than two weeks after the due date.**

Please plan to keep an electronic copy of each assignment until the end of the semester when you have received your final grade. All technological questions or problems should be directed to the Canvas Helpdesk (ph: 305-284-3949).

All work submitted for this course must be original to this course and to the student's academic career. All cases of plagiarism will be submitted to the Student Honor Council and Dean Overland of the Frost School of Music.

GRADING POLICY

- Exams—50%
- Participation Quizzes—15%
- Assignments—35%

GRADING SCALE

A+	(98-100)	B+	(87-89)	C+	(77-79)	D+	(67-69)
A	(93-97)	B	(83-86)	C	(73-76)	D	(63-66)
A-	(90-92)	B-	(80-82)	C-	(70-72)	D-	(60-62)
						F	(0-59)

CLASS SCHEDULE

The course calendar assures that students can complete the assignments in a timely fashion. You are responsible for all materials even though time constraints mean that only select topics and pieces will be discussed in class. You should consult the course calendar and note test dates and assignment deadlines. **Dates and deadlines are firm.** Manage your time so that you will not place yourself under unnecessary pressure during the semester. The course calendar is subject to change at the discretion of the instructor. (Please see the course calendar at the end of this syllabus.)

ATTENDANCE POLICY

You are expected to attend and participate in each class. You are required to attend 80% of the classes to receive a passing grade. In other words, if you miss more than six classes, you will fail the course. University Policy: “The University of Miami has no provision for unexcused absences. Attendance at all classes is expected. All excuses are to be submitted in writing for the instructor’s approval.”

Excused absences include documented illness, deaths in the family and other documented crises, call to active military duty or jury duty, religious holy days, and official University activities. These absences will be accommodated in a way that does not arbitrarily penalize students who have a valid excuse. Consideration will also be given to students whose dependent children experience serious illness.

- In terms of Holy Days, students must report to their instructor all holy days that will be observed during the semester within the **first six meetings of the course.**
- Absences and class work:
 - In the event that an excused absence will occur on a day when an assignment is due, the student is still required to turn it in on time to avoid a late penalty - generally, this means turning in the assignment the class period before the absence or sending the assignment in an email attachment to the instructor before class begins the day it is due. Assignments that are not turned in on time will be penalized (see Late Work Policy).
 - If an excused absence will occur on a day with a scheduled test, students must notify the instructor via email no later than **2 calendar weeks** in advance in order to make alternative plans for taking the assessment.
 - Makeup quizzes will only be given in the event of an excused absence, based on notifying the instructor within **3 days** after the due date. No make-up quizzes or exams will be given for unexcused absences and will result in a grade of zero.
 - Students that miss a class session should request a copy of the lecture notes from a trusted colleague. Each student is responsible for all material covered in class.
 - If you have a sudden excused absence (i.e., hospitalization, documented illness, funeral, etc), in order to get an absence excused for an exam, you must present documentation (i.e., doctor’s note, funeral program, etc.) within **two weeks** after missing the class. For example, if you miss an exam on 10/1, you have until 10/14 to bring the TA or the professor this documentation. **Documentation sent after this timeframe will not be considered, the absence will not be excused, and you will not be given a make-up exam.**

CLASSROOM EXPECTATIONS

The instructor and students will work together and strive for a classroom environment that maximizes teaching and learning in a courteous, tolerant, and positive forum allowing for critical and productive discussion. Students are expected to:

- Please refrain from conversations during the lecture portion of the class. This includes during the playing of musical examples! I will ask you to leave if you disrupt class with conversation.
- Raise your hand if you desire to speak or answer questions.
- Please turn your camera on when speaking.
- Avoid any inappropriate comments about race, gender, sexuality, religion, or any behavior that would be considered publicly inappropriate.

Important addendum to classroom expectations!!!! I don't expect everyone to be on "the same page" regarding what is appropriate or inappropriate, so if I believe you've said something offensive to another person or people group, I will let you know in class. Please do not take this personally. We are all on a learning journey, and I am constantly learning the best way of expressing my thoughts about a particular subject matter. This is a class about music-cultures who sometimes use misogynistic, crude, violent, religious, and even racist imagery and lyrics in their performances. It will likely be uncomfortable for some, so it's best to keep our discourse reserved and objective in nature.

HONOR CODE

Students will be bound by the University of Miami Honor Code. All reports, papers, written assignments, test papers, and examinations must be done without unofficial aid from devices or people. Students are responsible for the sole creation and completion of each assignment. Academic dishonesty will result in a minimum failure on each assignment and potential expulsion from the University.

Please read the complete undergraduate honor code at https://doso.studentaffairs.miami.edu/assets/pdf/honor-council/undergrad_honorcode.pdf. Your continued registration in this course will be understood to represent your commitment to the honor code as well as an acknowledgement that you have read and understand its policies. Any questions regarding this document should be directed to the instructor at the beginning of the semester.

The instructor assumes that all students understand the full meaning of the terms "cheating," "collusion," "multiple submission," and "plagiarism." These, as well as any other type of academic dishonesty, will not be tolerated in any form or for any reason, ignorance included. There is no situation in which presenting another's work or ideas as one's own is acceptable. Use proper citation so that you can benefit from the work of others while still crediting the originator of the idea. *All work for this course is expected to be original to and for this course and written solely by the individual student who claims authorship.*

AI USE

Use of AI is not permitted in writing papers. You must use traditional methods to help with grammar and spelling issues. If we suspect you are using AI, we will note that and confront you about the issue.

DISABILITIES

Any student with a documented disability (e.g. physical, learning, psychiatric, vision, hearing, etc.) who needs to arrange reasonable accommodations must contact the instructor and the Office of Disability Services (www.umarc@miami.edu) at the beginning of the semester.

SYLLABUS CHANGE POLICY

Except for changes that substantively affect the evaluation (grading) statement, this syllabus is a guide for the course and is subject to change with advance notice.

FROST SCHOOL OF MUSIC ACADEMIC RESILLIANCE PLAN:

In the event that the University of Miami's campus closes unexpectedly for an extended period of time due to a hurricane, pandemic, or other emergency situation that prevents this course from meeting in person, students should be prepared to continue their learning through other means as determined by the instructor. In the most likely

scenario, instruction would be delivered remotely through Canvas and other platforms. Students are expected to check their UM email account and course Canvas sites regularly for communications from their instructors, and to the extent feasible, continue their participation in their courses from their off-campus location by the alternate means determined by the instructor.

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COURSE CALENDAR

Reading and listening assignments are to be completed *prior* to the class in which they are scheduled for discussion. The numerals correspond to pages for reading in the textbook and the musical selections are for listening (on Canvas). This calendar is subject to change at the discretion of the instructor.

DATE		TOPICS FOR DISCUSSION/ IMPORTANT DUE DATES & EXAMS	
T	8/18	Introduction and Expectations; What is Hip-Hop? (Read Chapter 1 in textbook)	
H	8/20	Early contexts for hip-hop (Read Chapter 2 in textbook and watch <i>Wild Style</i> – on Canvas)	
T	8/25	Defining hip-hop culture: rupture, layering, and flow (Read pp. 17-26 in textbook)	
H	8/27	Defining hip-hop culture: rupture, layering, and flow continued (Read pp. 27-39 in textbook)	
T	9/1	The Black Atlantic: music-cultural flows from Africa to the diaspora (Read pp. 40-50 in textbook.)	
H	9/3	The Black Atlantic: music-cultural flows from Africa to the diaspora (Read pp. 50-56 in textbook.)	
T	9/8	Catch-up and Review and Listening Day!	
H	9/10	LISTENING EXAM 1	
T	9/15	Early Pioneers: First Wave (Read pp. 57-67 in textbook.)	
H	9/17	Early Pioneers: First Wave (Read pp. 57-67 in textbook.)	
T	9/22	Early Pioneers: Second Wave (Read pp. 67-79 in textbook.) Commercialization of hip-hop: MTV, whiteness, and crossovers (Read pp. 80-88 in textbook.)	
H	9/24	Early Pioneers: Second Wave (Read pp. 67-79 in textbook.)	
T	9/29	Commercialization of hip-hop: response rap, rap ballads and gender identity (Read pp. 88-98 in textbook.) Album Review Due 9/30	
H	10/1	Catch-up, Review, and Listening Day!!!	
T	10/6	LISTENING EXAM 2	
H	10/8	Regional styles: Miami Bass	

T	10/13	NO CLASS – FALL BREAK	
H	10/15	Regional Styles: Miami Bass, GoGo, and Baltimore Club Music	
T	10/20	East Coast Message rap (Read pp. 107-116 in textbook.) <u>Short Video Reflection 1 Due 10/21</u>	
H	10/22	West Coast Gangsta rap (Read pp. 116-134 in textbook.)	
T	10/27	G-Funk and the East Coast/West Coast Rivalry (Read pp. 142-150 in textbook.)	
H	10/29	The Legacy of Gangsta Rap	
T	11/3	Catch-up, Review, and Listening Day	
H	11/5	LISTENING EXAM 3	
T	11/10	Southern Rap, Bounce, Crunk, and other variations	
H	11/12	Hip-Hop and the #BLM movement: Jay-Z, Childish Gambino, Lil’ Baby, and Kendrick Lamar	
T	11/17	Globalization: Reggaetón and Latin Hip-Hop <u>Concert Review Due 11/18</u>	
H	11/19	Globalization: Arab Hip-Hop (WARNING VERY SENSITIVE MATERIAL) <u>Short Video Reflection 2 due 11/20</u>	
		THANKSGIVING BREAK	
T	12/1	Globalization: Asian Hip-Hop	
TH	12/3	Final Exam 5-7:30	